recently, to also provide yearly donations for the upkeep of the local Mansingh Masjid, a mosque still prefixed with their Hindu surname and built over 150 years ago by an ancestor. The Masjid was built on family land that was later sold off. Its nineteenth-century spires, built opposite what was once the family mansion's main gate, are surrounded today by a row of modern houses but it still retains its Hindu nomenclature. At the centre of its prayer hall is a foundation plaque in black stone, recording its founding by a Mansingh, accompanied by a verse from the Quran.

For my father-in-law, the Quran was a treasured family 'virasat' (heritage), part of his lived daily tradition. Yet, his household also distributed motichoor ke laddoo as ritual prasad to neighbours to celebrate the Ram Temple consecration ceremony. The laddoos had been specially sent out from the Ayodhya temple, where Modi performed the rituals, to several households across UP, and had reached them via relatives in Allahabad.

Their story encapsulates for me the multiple contradictions of India, the complexities of Hinduism and Hindu nationalism beyond simple binaries, and equally, the questions it raises for the future of older, syncretic traditions. This ability to straddle two religious worlds, well-studied by anthropologists, historians and writers, would be familiar to many Indians from a small-town or rural milieu. Even now, dargahs (shrines to revered figures, often Sufi saints or dervishes) draw people of all faiths, and Indians, cutting across religions, look to pirs and other religious figures to ward off evil.

This is why an understanding of the nature of the BJP's growth, its structures of power and modes of mobilisation is critical today. The answers may be surprising.



Hindu nationalism, and the political idea of a Hindu-focused India, is not a new ideational construct. It was already a fully developed alternative political ideology by the time of independent India's first election in 1951-52. It evolved into a political force in the form of the BJP's predecessor, the Bharatiya Jan Sangh,[10] which stood in direct opposition on first principles to the Nehruvian notion of a republic